The Objective Ledger

Understanding yourself and
the people you share a life with



The whole book · Short version

All three parts: yourself, between us, and understanding people.

CHRISTIAN

The Objective Ledger

THE WHOLE BOOK · SHORT VERSION

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CHRISTIAN

Spread Love & Acceptance
spreadloveandacceptance.com

The Objective Ledger: The whole book, the short version.
By Christian. Spread Love & Acceptance.

This edition: October 2026. Made from the chapters at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book, where they are kept up to date.

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Not therapy. This book is general education about people and relationships. It is not a diagnosis, treatment or a replacement for help from a doctor, counsellor or other trained professional, and it can't know your situation.

If you are not safe. If you feel afraid of someone you live with, or someone controls your money, phone or movements, that is not a problem to fix with a worksheet. spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety lists free, private help. If you are in danger now, call your local emergency number.

The examples are made up. The people in the scenes and examples are invented, built from common patterns. None of them is a real person or a testimonial.

Research mentioned in the chapters is listed, with links, in the research notes at the back and at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Set in Lora, Fraunces and IBM Plex Mono.

If you need help now

If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, or someone is in danger right now, call your local emergency number: 999 in the UK, 112 or 999 in Ireland, 911 in the US and Canada, 000 in Australia, 111 in New Zealand.

If you are struggling, or worried about someone else, you can talk to a trained person now. These lines are free, private and open day and night. You don't have to be sure it is a crisis to call or text.

WHERE YOU ARE	CALL OR TEXT
United States	Call or text **988** (the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or chat at 988lifeline.org. You can also text HOME to **741741** (Crisis Text Line).
United Kingdom	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**. Or text SHOUT to **85258** (Shout, a free text line).
Ireland	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**.
Canada	Call or text **9-8-8** (the Suicide Crisis Helpline), in English or French.
Australia	Call Lifeline on **13 11 14**, or text 0477 13 11 14.
New Zealand	Call or text **1737** (Need to talk?).
Anywhere else	**findahelpline.com** lists free helplines in many countries, by phone, text and chat.

For children and young people

UK	Childline, **0800 1111** (free, for anyone under 19)
Ireland	Childline, **1800 66 66 66** (free, for anyone up to 18)
Canada	Kids Help Phone, **1-800-668-6868**, or text CONNECT to 686868

Australia	Kids Helpline, **1800 55 1800** (ages 5 to 25)
New Zealand	Youthline, **0800 376 633**, or text 234
US	988 is for every age.

If you're worried about someone

Ask them plainly: "Are you thinking about ending your life?" Studies have found that asking does not put the idea in someone's head, and talking about it may even ease it. Listen, stay with them if you can, and call or text one of the lines above together. Part Three, Chapter 12, page says more about helping someone in a crisis, and Chapter 16, page about worry, low mood and when to get help.

This book is general education, not a crisis service. The website's tools keep what you type on your own device, so nobody there can see it or reply to it. The numbers were checked in October 2026. Numbers can change; findahelpline.com keeps an up-to-date list.

How to use this book

This is a book about seeing what is really going on, in yourself and between people, without blaming anyone, and then changing one small thing. This copy holds 26 chapters in three parts, in the short version. There is no wrong way in.

THE PARTS

Part One: Yourself. Where you came from, who you are now and who you are becoming. You can read all of it on your own.

Part Two: Between us. One idea per chapter about sharing a life, a home or work with someone, each with a worksheet that puts it to use.

Part Three: Understanding people. How feelings, stress, trust, change, grief, groups and love work, for anyone, in any kind of relationship.

TWO SIZES OF EVERY CHAPTER

Every chapter comes in a short version (about 10 to 15 minutes) and a full version with the research, more examples and more to try. This is the short version. The full version is free at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book.

READ IN ORDER, OR BY NEED

Read it front to back like any book, or start with the chapter that fits what is going on. Each chapter ends with *What to remember*, *This connects to* (the chapters that explain it or put it to use, with page numbers) and *Put it to use*, with codes you can scan for the matching tool.

IN EVERY CHAPTER

- A short scene: a made-up moment from everyday life.
- **Words you could use**: sentences to say out loud.
- **Try this**: one small thing to do this week.
- **Common mix-ups**: easy mistakes, and what is closer to true.

THE SITE, THE PROGRAM AND PROFESSOR PUDDLES

The book has a free website with the tools and worksheets the chapters mention. Nothing you type there leaves your device, and there is no account. The **six-week program** (spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01) puts Part Two to work a week at a time, and the **self path** does the same for Part One. **Professor Puddles**, the site's friendly guide, answers questions about the book's ideas.

GO GENTLY

Some chapters touch hard things: grief, shame, anger, worry, trauma. Skip anything that isn't right for today. Nothing here is a test, and nothing needs to be done all at once.

Find it fast

Start with what is going on, not with chapter one. Each line points to the place in the book that helps most, and one tool to try. You can read that part on its own and stop.

SHARING THE LOAD

IF THIS IS GOING ON	READ	PAGE	TRY
We keep arguing about chores.	Part Two · Chapter II · One owner per job	**18**	One owner per job
I do the remembering and planning, and nobody sees it (the mental load).	Preface to Part Two · The mental load		Who did what
We each think we do more than our share.	Preface to Part Two · Why the other person doesn't see it		Who did what
The same job keeps slipping, week after week.	Part Two · Chapter V · A repeat usually has no real owner		What keeps coming back?
Is the way we share things fair? Can it last?	Part Two · Chapter II · The setup score	**18**	Is the setup working for everyone?
We've just had a baby and we're both exhausted.	Part Two · Chapter II · Small children and a new baby	**32**	How much are you carrying?
We're about to move in together.	Part Two · Chapter V · Starting out: before you move in		The Lemonade Stand
Money between us feels unfair.	Part Two · Chapter IV · Money between you		The Lemonade Stand: the Money tab
We co-parent across two homes.	Part Two · Chapter III · Two homes		One owner per job
We share a house with a housemate, or more than two of us share a home.	Part Two · Chapter IV · A couple and a housemate		The Lemonade Stand
I'm raising my grandchild (kinship care).	Part Two · Chapter V · Raising a grandchild		One owner per job
Faith matters to us, or family elders expect a say.	Part Two · Chapter I · Faith, culture and family voices		The 90-second daily check-in

IF THIS IS GOING ON	READ	PAGE	TRY
I'm caring for a parent or partner, and it's wearing me down.	Part Three · Chapter 12 · Your limits make your help last		How much are you carrying?
I'm the only one who wants to try this.	Part Two · Chapter II · When only one of you is on board	**36**	Who did what (your side only)
Someone handed me this book, and I'm not sure why.	If someone handed you this book	**11**	One owner per job

TALKING IT THROUGH

IF THIS IS GOING ON	READ	PAGE	TRY
Small things turn into big rows.	Part Two · Chapter I · How stress changes your frequency		The Calm-Down Kit
One of us goes quiet and the other pushes for an answer.	Part Three · Chapter 5 · Feeling safe with someone		The Calm-Down Kit: our pause plan
Texts and messages keep landing wrong.	Part Three · Chapter 4 · Messages lose their tone		Text message checker
We move and talk at different speeds.	Part Two · Chapter I · What sets the frequency		Same moment, different speeds
A comment stings and I snap back.	Part Two · Chapter IV · Let a comment land before you react		Say it so it lands
We need to say sorry and mend things.	Part Three · Chapter 11 · A real apology		Say it so it lands
Conflict at work, with a colleague or in a team.	Part Three · Chapter 4 · Saying hard things kindly		Say it so it lands
Is it us, or is it everything else going on?	Part Two · Chapter III · Leftover stress		Is it us, or is it everything else?

KNOWING YOURSELF

IF THIS IS GOING ON	READ	PAGE	TRY
I can't tell what I'm feeling.	Part One · Now · When feelings are hard to name		Today's Weather
I'm wiped out and everything feels like too much.	Part One · Now · Check your weather; one state, many words		How much are you carrying?
ADHD: I'm overwhelmed and keep forgetting things.	Part Three · Chapter 9 · ADHD, time and motivation		Wiring Card

IF THIS IS GOING ON	READ	PAGE	TRY
I'm autistic, and people keep misreading me (or I misread them).	Part One · Now · A mix-up runs both ways		Wiring Card
Old rules from childhood still run my reactions.	Part One · Then · Write down the rulebook from home		The self path: where your lens came from
My inner critic is loud.	Part Three · Chapter 7 · The critic and the soothing system		The Calm-Down Kit
I want to change a habit, but it keeps slipping.	Part One · Next · Tiny, repeatable steps		The self path, step by step

HARD SEASONS

IF THIS IS GOING ON	READ	PAGE	TRY
Someone I love has died.	Part Three · Chapter 8 · Grief comes in waves		When you've lost someone
I feel lonely, or I live on my own.	Part Three · Chapter 5 · Building connection from where you are		Living on your own, living well
A teenager's anger, or I'm a teenager and I'm angry.	Part Three · Chapter 13 · The hot minutes		The Calm-Down Kit
Left out of a group, a friend group or a group chat.	Part Three · Chapter 17 · Groups online, and their pull		Text message checker
Worry keeps me awake, or my mood is low.	Part Three · Chapter 16 · Worry time; low mood		How much are you carrying?
I'm thinking about ending my life, or I'm worried someone is.	If you need help now	5	The page itself

The tools are free on the website, with nothing to sign up for; each chapter's end has a code you can scan for its tools. Looking for a word rather than a problem? The index at the back lists the main ideas.

If someone handed you this book

Maybe it was left on your side of the bed with a page turned down. Maybe someone said, "Could you just read this bit?" Either way, you didn't choose it. Fair enough. Here is the short version, written for you.

This isn't a case against you

The book starts from something researchers have found again and again: when two people each estimate their share of the housework, the two answers usually add up to more than 100%. Nobody is lying. You see every minute of your own effort and only some of theirs, and so do they (Chapter II, page **18**). So the book never asks who the bad guy is. Its numbers score the setup, never a person.

What's in it for you

- Fewer repeat arguments about the same jobs.
- Jobs that are clearly yours, so nobody needs to remind you about them.
- Credit for what you already do. Your jobs go on the list too: the car, the bins, the late-night lifts, the things you fix.
- A say in what "fair" means in your house. It isn't always 50/50 (Chapter IV, page).

It doesn't ask for therapy talk, and you never fill anything in about the other person. You can say no.

A first week: three small things

1. **Log your own week.** Rough minutes on "Who did what", including the thinking part: booking, remembering, planning. Ten minutes in all. Only yours, never theirs.
2. **Ask one question, and just listen.** "What's the one job you'd most like to stop thinking about?" Don't defend or count. Write the answer down.
3. **Take over that job, the whole of it,** including the noticing (below).

Words to open the talk

> "I read the bit you gave me. I don't agree with all of it, but I get the point about the stuff nobody sees."
> "I'd rather own a couple of things properly than 'help' with everything. Which one would you most like off your mind?"
> "Give me a week to see what I actually do. Then let's look together."

Best left out, for now: "Just tell me what to do" (it hands the thinking straight back), "You should have asked" and, in the first five minutes, "I do loads too." That may be true. Save it for when you both have your logs.

Taking over a whole job, noticing included

Every job has a part you can see (doing it) and parts you can't: noticing it needs doing, remembering, planning and checking it got done (the Preface, page). Taking a job over means all of it.

1. **Pick one job that repeats:** the children's clothes and shoes, the bins, the car, school forms, the dentist.
2. **Get the handover once.** What it involves, when it's due, where things are, who to call. Ask your questions now, not every week.
3. **Move the remembering out of their head.** A phone reminder, the calendar, a list on the fridge: anywhere but the other person.
4. **Do it start to finish for a month** without being reminded. If you need reminding, fix your reminder, not the relationship.
5. **Do it your way.** If the result is fine, the method is yours. Their part is to let it be done differently.
6. **Ask for a backstop if you like:** someone who notices a slip and says so once, kindly. A backstop isn't a supervisor (Chapter II, page **18**).

A made-up example. Hester has always looked after the children's clothes: spotting toes at the end of shoes, school sizes, swimming kit, passing on what's outgrown. Wilf takes it over. Hester writes the handover note: sizes, the shop, which drawer holds the next size up. Wilf sets a reminder for the first Sunday of each month: "Shoes, uniform, kit." In week two he misses the PE kit for a school trip. Hester says once, "The trip kit is Thursday," and he adds "school letters" to his Sunday check. A month in, Hester says the biggest change is that she no longer thinks about shoes at eleven at night.

If you think it's already fair

Log your week anyway. If it comes out even, that is useful to know, and the book will say so: a fair score doesn't silence anyone, and a low one doesn't blame anyone. And if this book feels like the wrong place to start, Find it fast, page **8** lists other ways in.

The book in two pictures

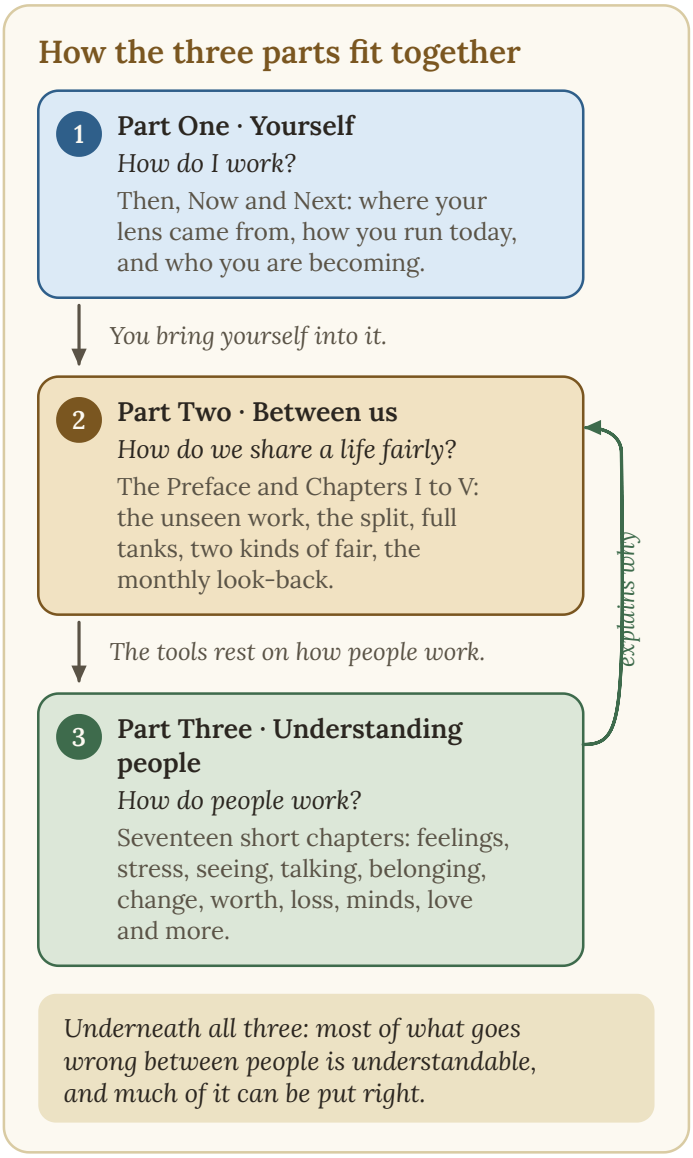


FIGURE 1 How the three parts fit together: you bring yourself into every shared life, and Part Three explains why the Part Two tools work.

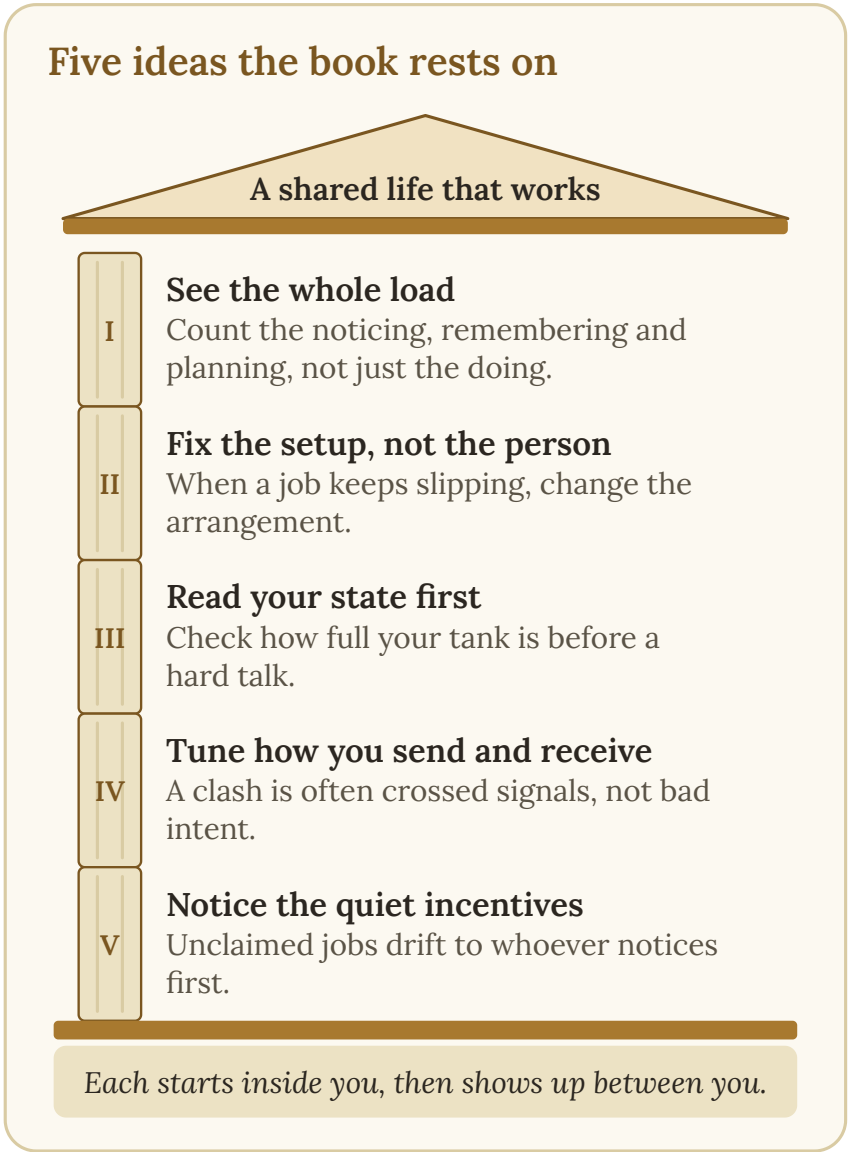


FIGURE 2 Five ideas the whole book rests on. Each one starts inside you, then shows up between you and the people you share a life with.

Contents

If you need help now 5

How to use this book 7

Find it fast 8

If someone handed you this book 11

The book in two pictures 14

Part Two **Between us** 17

II Is the split working? A fair look at chores at home 18

How the numbers work 39

Blank worksheets 46

Words used in this book 57

List of figures 62

List of filled-in examples 63

Research notes 64

Index 67



PART TWO

Between us

One idea per chapter about sharing a life, a home or work with someone, each with a worksheet that puts it to use.

IN THIS PART

Chapter II Is the split working? 18

II

PART TWO · CHAPTER II

Is the split working? A fair look at chores at home

One gentle question: can the way you share the work keep going, or is one of you quietly running on empty?

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Look at the month, not last night
2. Three things go in
3. Balance: how the hours split
4. Ownership: does each job have a name?
5. Stress: how full each stress tank is
6. One number comes out, from 0 to 1
7. Start with the biggest shortfall
8. It judges the setup, never a person
9. Words this chapter uses
10. Inside you, and between you
11. On your own: is your own load working?
12. The fields behind this chapter
13. In real life
14. Common mix-ups
15. Small children and a new baby
16. If only one of you wants to try this
17. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **Look at the month, not last night.** Use what you both wrote down, not memory.
- **Three things go in:** balance (how the hours split), ownership (does each job have a name?) and stress (how full each tank is).
- **One number comes out, from 0 to 1.** Start with whichever part pulled it down most.
- **It judges the setup, never a person.** It's where a talk starts, not how one ends.

ANY GIVEN WEEK

One of you is quietly doing eleven small things a day that the other has never had to think about. When the other one says it feels even, they mean it. From inside each person's own week, it does.

01

Look at the month, not last night.

When people ask "Is this working?", the answer usually comes from whatever happened most recently. This chapter asks a calmer question, using what you both wrote down. Re-ask it every few months, even when things seem fine, because a split that worked once can quietly go stale.

For example: Two housemates had one awful week of dishes. The whole month showed three fine weeks and one exam week.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"Can we look at the whole month before we decide anything?"

TRY THIS:
Put a short check in your calendar for about a month from now.

02

Three things go in.

How evenly the hours are shared. Whether every regular job has a clear owner (the job list, One owner per job (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-03-one-owner-per-job)). And how stressed each of you already is from everything else going on.

A **workpaper** is one of the site's free fill-in worksheets. You don't need any of them to start. Rough notes on paper work too.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"Let's each bring our own numbers, so neither of us has to guess."

TRY THIS:
Open the three worksheets once, just to see what they ask.

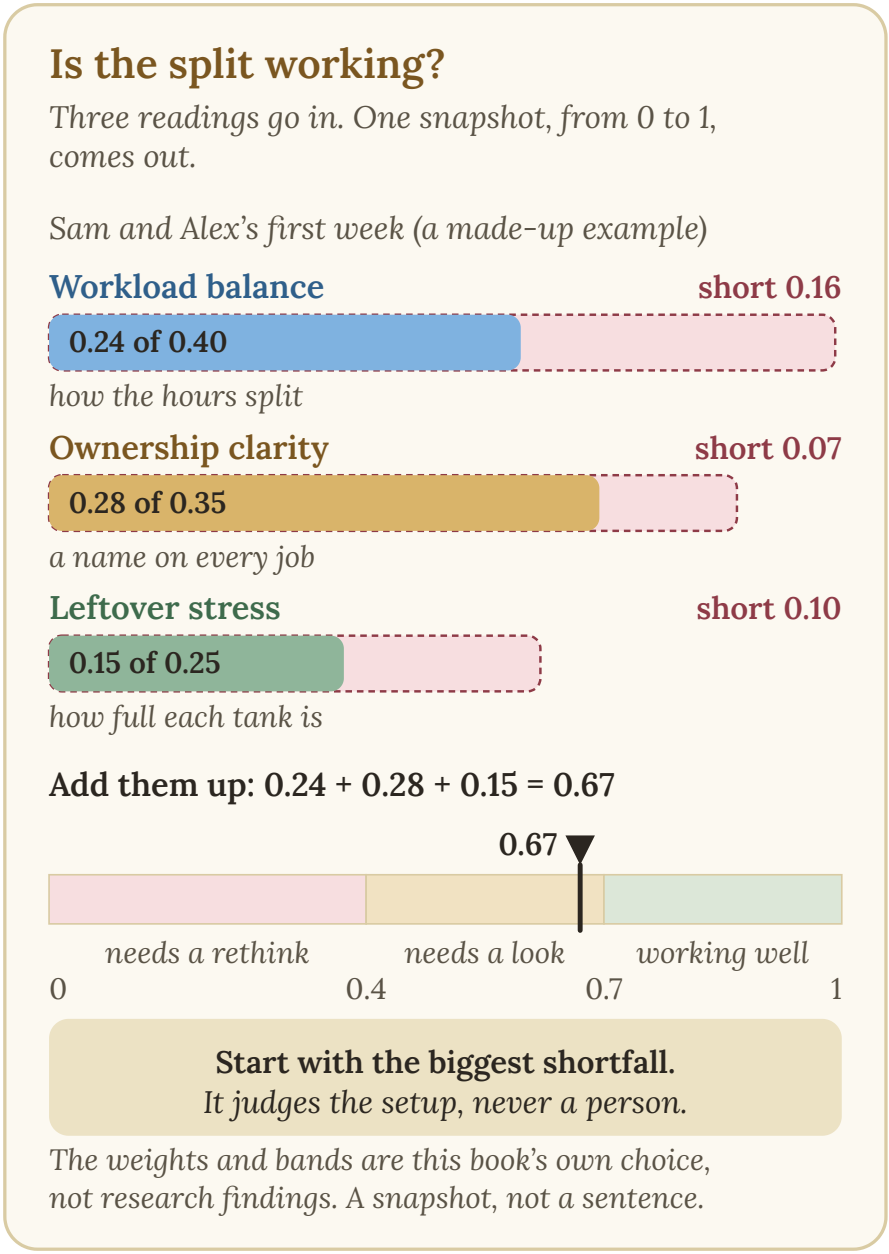


FIGURE 13 Is the split working? Three readings go in and one snapshot comes out. Start with the biggest shortfall. It judges the setup, never a person.

03

Balance: how the hours split.

From your week-long logs, work out each person's share of the hours. An even split scores 1. One person doing everything scores 0. It doesn't matter which person is doing more. If you agreed an uneven split that suits you (say, one of you works longer hours outside the home), compare against that split instead.

For example: Three partners log 30 hours of home jobs: 15, 9 and 6. An even share is 10 each.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'm not keeping score of you. I just want us both to see the hours."

TRY THIS:
Log one week each, and include the small jobs that take under ten minutes.

Three or more of you? Compare each person's share with an even share (100 ÷ number of people), or with a split you agreed. The Lemonade Stand (spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand), a free page where each person lists their hours, does the arithmetic.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 8

The Lemonade Stand: quick look
Wren, Josh and Mei, housemates (Wren's view)

Quick look: who does what at home

Mark who mostly does each job. The picture builds as you go, the thinking work too.

Your name
Wren

Their name
Josh

Person 3
Mei

Job	Who mostly does it
Dishes	*Shared*
Laundry	*Shared*
Cleaning the bathroom	*Josh*
Cooking dinner	*Mei*
Grocery shopping	*Wren*
Paying bills	*Wren*
Noticing what's running low	*Wren*
Planning the week	*Mei*
Remembering dates and appointments	*Wren*

HOW IT LOOKS

Here's how it looks from your side, 9 jobs so far.

Everyday jobs: mostly shared. 6 jobs: Wren 2 · Josh 1 · Mei 1 · Shared 2.

Planning and remembering: mostly Wren. 3 jobs: Wren 2 · Mei 1.

The thinking work is easy to miss, because nobody sees it happen. Saying it out loud is a good start.

Does this match how it feels to the three of you?

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. Pets and booking appointments were taken off the list: they don't happen in this house.

Fill in your own: The Lemonade Stand quick look
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand)

04

Ownership: does each job have a name?

Each job gets two names: the owner, who does the job start to finish, and a backstop, who notices if it slipped and gently checks in (never a supervisor). It can be the same person, though a second name gives the job a gentle check. Count the jobs that have an owner, then divide by all the jobs on the

list. (The backstop is a good habit on top, but the count only needs the owner.) Leave jobs nobody owns on the list. They are the ones that matter most.

A *decision* you make together, like which school, can be marked "Both (decide together)". It counts as owned, because a decision needs both voices. A *job* that needs doing gets one name.

For example: Two sisters care for their dad. Nobody owned his prescription, so each thought the other had ordered it.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Can we put a name next to this one, so it doesn't fall between us?"

> TRY THIS:
> Find one job with no name, and give it an owner and a backstop today.

05

Stress: how full each stress tank is.

Each of you rates how full your own stress tank is with How much are you carrying? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying). A higher score means more stress. Under 0.30 is low, 0.30 up to 0.60 is moderate, and 0.60 or more is high. The score uses the average of your scores. But if either of you is at 0.60 or more, talk about that first, even when the score looks fine. A setup that only works when you're both well rested isn't one that can last, so more stress lowers the result.

For example: A grandmother raising two grandchildren scores 0.70. Her son, who helps at weekends, scores 0.35. Her 0.70 is the headline.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "My tank is high this week. Can we plan around that, not around the average?"

TRY THIS:

Each of you scores your own tank on the same day, before looking at the other's.

06

One number comes out, from 0 to 1.

0.70 or above: *working well*, the setup is holding. From 0.40 up to 0.70: *needs a look*, something is drifting, often who owns what. Below 0.40: *needs a rethink, together*. (The result is called the setup score. It looks like a probability, but it isn't one. It's a simple weighted sum.)

A **weighted sum** means each part counts for a set share: the hours count most, then the owners, then stress.

For example: Two friends who run a café score 0.55. Nothing is broken, but something is drifting.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"This number is about our setup, not about us."

TRY THIS:

Write the date next to your number, so you can compare next month.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 9

Is the setup working for everyone?
Rosemary and Ken, retired, married 41 years

Is the setup working for everyone?

Person 1 (optional)
Rosemary

Person 2 (optional)
Ken

1. How the hours split

From Who did what or the Lemonade Stand: each person's total hours for the week.

Rosemary, hours
14

Ken, hours
10

2. Does each job have a name?

From One owner per job.

Jobs on the list
12

Jobs with an owner
9

3. How much each person is carrying

Each person's own score from How much are you carrying? Everyone fills in their own.

Rosemary, load (0 to 1)
0.45

Ken, load (0 to 1)
0.30

HOW THE SETUP IS WORKING

Working well

0.75 of 1. The setup is carrying its own weight.

Next: nothing in the setup needs changing this week. Keep the same rhythm of check-ins.

If you want to nudge it higher one day (optional, not urgent): hand about 2 hours a week from Rosemary to Ken, and balance would go from 0.83 to 1.00. Give one more job an owner (the person who does it and sees it through), and ownership would go from 0.75 to 0.83.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. It scores the setup, never a person, and never the relationship as a whole.

Fill in your own: Is the setup working for everyone?
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/calculators/is-the-setup-working-quick)

07

Start with the biggest shortfall.

The single number matters less than which of the three parts pulled it down most. In the middle band that is often ownership, which is why the calculator suggests One owner per job first. Once you've both seen it, what you do next is a choice you make together.

The **shortfall** is how far one part fell below the most it could add.

For example: Separated parents score 0.62. Their biggest gap: nobody owns school forms. They fix only that.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Which part pulled the number down most? Let's start there."

TRY THIS:
Choose one small change, not five.

08

It judges the setup, never a person.

The number isn't a verdict on who's better or whether the relationship works. It's where a conversation starts, never how one ends. These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking about the split ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

For example: One partner sees 0.35: "So I'm the problem." The other: "No. The bathroom has no owner, and you work nights."

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Whatever this shows, I'm on your side."

TRY THIS:

Before you start, agree that either of you can say “pause” and come back later.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. The score describes the setup you share, but your levers are your own: your jobs, your hours and what you agree to take on. You can propose a fix; you can’t make the other person accept it. If the balance stays one-sided, step your load back towards your share on purpose, and say so kindly. Matching effort with effort protects your stress tank, and your tank is part of the score too. More in Part One: who you are today

SUNDAY EVENING

Two week-long logs and two cups of tea. One list has 31 rows. The other has 18. Nobody says anything for a moment. Then one of you says, “I honestly didn’t know about half of these.”

Words this chapter uses

- **Log:** a simple list of the jobs you did this week and roughly how long each took.
- **Owner:** the person who does a job from start to finish, including remembering it.
- **Backstop:** the person who notices if a job slipped and gently checks in. A helper, never a boss.
- **Stress tank:** how much stress you are already carrying from the rest of life.
- **Setup:** the way you share the work right now. It can always be changed.
- **Setup score:** one number from 0 to 1 that sums up the three readings. It describes the setup, never a person.

Invisible jobs count too. Planning meals, remembering birthdays, booking the vet and noticing the soap is running low are all work, even though nobody sees them happen. Put them in your log.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'd like to add the thinking jobs to our list, like remembering and planning. They take time too."

Inside you, and between you

- **In you:** See your own share honestly, from what you wrote down rather than from memory. See the way you share work as a setup you can redesign, not a flaw in you.
- **Between you and others:** Put both people's numbers on one page, and read the result as a note about the setup, never a verdict on a person. Clear owners leave less room for blame.

On your own: is your own load working?

This chapter asks whether a shared setup can last. You can ask the same about your own week: are you spending more energy than comes back in?

- Add up what you carry: jobs, people and worries.
- Set it beside what refills you: rest, help, and people who give back.
- If it runs in the red, change your side: drop, delay, ask or say no kindly. A limit is a statement about supply, not about your worth.

For example: After a breakup, Leanne has her kids every other week, and fills the quiet weeks with favours for friends. Writing it down showed her she never rests. More in On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'd love to help, and I can't this week. Can I let you know next week?"

TRY THIS:

Tonight, write three things that drained you this week and one thing that refilled you.

IN THE INDIVIDUAL PROGRAM:

Step 1: check your battery (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) · Step 6: kind ways to say no · Part One: matching energy (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now-in-depth) · The whole book on sharing the load (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/topic-share-the-load)

The fields behind this chapter

This chapter draws on 6 of the author's thirteen fields (see the Preface or the About page). The first few:

- **Finance** (See the whole load): Like a small shop asking whether it can keep paying its bills, month after month. The chapter reads the setup that way, never as a verdict on the people.
- **Business** (Fix the setup, not the person): Ownership clarity: one owner per job, borrowed from project work, and the maker-and-checker habit from internal controls. Every regular job gets a person who does it and a backstop who notices if it slipped.
- **Neurobiology** (Read your state first): Leftover stress: a quick self-rating of the stress you're already carrying. It borrows the idea that stress builds up in the body, but it doesn't measure your body.
- **Economics** (See the whole load): Limited capacity and the safety margin.

Two fields, one idea: Business + Economics. Unowned work falls to whoever notices first, every time. That's what turns a fixable imbalance into a repeating one, so the check counts owners, not just the hours.

In real life

- **Partners:** After a new baby arrives, the hours tip heavily one way without anyone deciding it. The check can show it before resentment builds.

- **Family:** Two siblings share care for a parent. One lives nearby and does most of the visits. Writing down the hours helps them rebalance in other ways, like paperwork and phone calls.
- **Roommates:** Everyone agrees cleaning matters, but nobody owns the bathroom. The ownership score shows the gap straight away.
- **Coworkers:** Two people share one role. The same three questions still work: how the hours split, who owns what, and how stretched each person is.
- **Two dads:** With no old script for who does what, nothing was decided. One of them quietly took on all the school messages.
- **More than two partners:** In a home of three or more, "someone will do it" often means nobody does. Owners matter even more. See More than two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two).
- **Foster and kinship carers:** Meetings, forms and contact visits are real work. See Foster and kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship).
- **Shift workers:** Hours can look even while sleep is not. See Different hours (spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours).
- **When one of you is ill:** Share by energy, and agree an uneven split on purpose. See When one of you is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill).
- **Dorm roommates:** A room agreement with names next to jobs settles most of it. See Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I think the way we split things worked before, and life changed. Can we look at it again together?"

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 10

Our room agreement

Kayla and Bea, first-year roommates

Our room agreement

Your name
Kayla

Their name
Bea

Quiet hours
11 pm to 7 am on weeknights, midnight on Fridays and Saturdays. Headphones after that.

Guests (daytime)
Fine with a quick text first. Not during the other one's study or sleep time.

Overnight guests
Up to 2 nights a week, agreed the day before. A guest doesn't stay in the room when their host isn't there.

Cleaning
Kayla: floor and bins, Sunday. Bea: desk area and the fridge, Wednesday. Our own laundry, our own job.

Borrowing
Ask first, every time. Food on the shared shelf is for both of us.

Lights and alarms
Big light off by 11:30 on weeknights; a desk lamp is fine. One alarm, one snooze at most.

How we bring up problems
Text first if that's easier, then talk within a few days, one topic at a time. If we're stuck, we ask our RA to help.

YOUR AGREEMENT, READY TO SEND

Our room agreement (Kayla and Bea), with every line above, ending: "We'll look at it again together in a month."

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. They kept most of the site's starting point and changed two lines.

Fill in your own: Our room agreement (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room)

Common mix-ups

- **"A low number means the relationship is failing."** It only means the current setup needs changing. Setups change all the time.
- **"A high number means nobody can complain."** A good score never silences anyone. If something feels wrong, say so.
- **"We can just guess the numbers."** A guessed number is really just a feeling with a decimal point. Use your written logs.
- **"Taking unowned jobs off the list will help."** It raises the number and changes nothing at home.
- **"One of us can fill it in for both."** Each person writes their own log and scores their own stress tank.
- **"Fair means exactly 50/50."** Fair is what you both agree to, with eyes open. An uneven split you chose together can be fair. Chapter IV covers the kinds of fair.
- **"The backstop checks up on the owner."** No. The backstop only notices if something slipped, and asks kindly. It is help, not a check on someone.

Small children and a new baby

Small children bring a flood of new jobs, and most of them are thinking jobs: the nursery bag, the jabs, the party invites, the next size of clothes, the night

wakings. That's why the mental load (see the Preface) often grows after a baby arrives, usually without anyone deciding it.

- **Log the kid jobs too,** with the thinking time. Nights count.
- **Hand over whole jobs, not tasks:** the clothes and sizes, the nursery bag, the GP and jabs. The new owner does the noticing too, in their own way.
- **Baby on the way?** Write your first job list together before the birth, plan the nights, and agree to look again at six weeks, three months, and before either of you goes back to work.
- **In the first weeks, share by energy, not hours.** Whoever was up in the night gets the rest; the other takes the morning.

For example (made up): Hollie and Gareth have Alfie, 3, and Poppy, 8 months. Gareth is a paramedic on shifts. Their logged minutes come out nearly even, but Hollie did almost three-quarters of the jobs nobody asked for. They don't move minutes. They move one whole job, the children's clothes, to Gareth.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Could you own the nursery bag from now on, including noticing when we're low on nappies? I won't check it."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 11

Who did what, with small children

Hollie and Gareth, parents of a toddler and a baby; Gareth works shifts

Who did what

Person A
Hollie

Person B
Gareth

Week beginning
12 October 2026

Part A: Who did what, this week

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?
Mon	*Pack the nursery bag: spare clothes, nappies, named milk*	*Hollie*	10	*Noticed and handled*
Tue	*Book Poppy's one-year jabs at the GP*	*Hollie*	15	*Noticed and handled*
Tue	*Bath and bedtime, both children*	*Gareth*	45	*Asked for*
Wed	*Reply to a party invite and buy the present*	*Hollie*	25	*Noticed and handled*
Wed	*Sort outgrown clothes and order the next size*	*Hollie*	40	*Noticed and handled*
Thu	*Plan the week's meals around Gareth's nights*	*Hollie*	20	*Thinking and planning*
Thu	*Cook dinner and batch-cook for the weekend*	*Gareth*	75	*Noticed and handled*
Fri	*Remember the nursery photo money and form*	*Hollie*	10	*Thinking and planning*

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?
Fri	*Night wakings with Poppy*	*Hollie*	60	*Noticed and handled*
Sat	*Swimming lesson with Alfie*	*Gareth*	60	*Asked for*
Sat	*Big food shop and nappies*	*Both*	80	*Asked for*
Sun	*Washing for both children, to put away*	*Hollie*	50	*Noticed and handled*
Sun	*Fix the stair gate*	*Gareth*	20	*Noticed and handled*
Sun	*Update the family calendar and the childcare rota*	*Hollie*	20	*Thinking and planning*

THIS WEEK'S TOTALS

Hollie
290 minutes (55%), of which 250 noticed and handled without being asked (50 of them thinking and planning)

Gareth
240 minutes (45%), of which 95 noticed and handled without being asked

Workload balance score
0.91. It describes how the logged work was split this week, not anyone in it.

Unasked-for work
Hollie did 72% of the work that was noticed and handled without anyone asking. This is the work that is easiest to miss. Say it out loud, and give the jobs that repeat a named owner.

Part B (optional): Kind ways to say no

Left blank this week.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. Gareth worked three night shifts this week, so his rows are fewer; the minutes are close, and the noticing is

the part to talk about.

Fill in your own: Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01)

If only one of you wants to try this

That is common, and you can still start. Log your own week and score your own tank. Then share one small thing you noticed, without asking the other person to agree with your numbers.

For example: A dad noticed he spent five hours a week driving his teenage son around. He just said so, and they agreed a bus pass for two days a week. See Teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I tried writing down my week, just for me. Can I show you one thing I noticed?"

TRY THIS:

Share one finding, not the whole list. Then let it rest for a few days.

If the other person refuses to talk about the split at all, ever, or makes you feel afraid for raising it, that isn't a setup problem. Please read Not safe at home?

More for your situation

Money together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together) · Gaming and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together) · Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends) · Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · Grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children) · Grandparents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grandparents) · Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting) · Coming home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · Empty nest (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest) · At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work) · For counsellors (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors)

TRY THIS:

Each of you logs one week in Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-01), first. The number only means something if you each wrote your own.

Next, fill in the job list in One owner per job together, including any jobs nobody owns yet.

Then each of you scores how full your own stress tank is in How much are you carrying? on the same day.

Put the three numbers into the calculator. Look first at the biggest shortfall, pick one small change together, and check again in a month.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Look at the month, not last night.** Use what you both wrote down, not memory.
- ✓ **Three things go in:** balance (how the hours split), ownership (does each job have a name?) and stress (how full each tank is).
- ✓ **One number comes out, from 0 to 1.** Start with whichever part pulled it down most.
- ✓ **It judges the setup, never a person.** It's where a talk starts, not how one ends.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Preface to Part Two · The work nobody sees
The unseen work the check counts — online

Part Two · Chapter III · Full tanks and different angles
The stress input, explained — online

Part Three · Chapter 6 · Habits and change
Fixing the setup with small, kind changes — online

Part Three · Chapter 12 · Helping others well
When one person carries the care — online

PUT IT TO USE



Six-week program, week 2: give every job one owner
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01



One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-03-one-owner-per-job

How the numbers work

Every number in this book is arithmetic you can do with a pencil. None of them is a test, a diagnosis or a verdict on anyone: they describe a week, a load or a way of sharing work. The weights and cut-offs are this book's own rules of thumb, not research findings, and you are free to disagree with them. The worked examples are the book's own, so you can check them against the chapters.

Two habits run through all of them. **Scores are rounded to two decimal places before their band is read,** so the number you see and the words you see always agree. And **nobody's score is ever worked out for them:** if someone's own answer is missing, the total waits.

The load: How much are you carrying?

You score five things from 0 (not at all) to 4 (very true), about the last day or two: sleep debt, workload elsewhere, unresolved conflict, your physical state, and time pressure today.

```
load = (sleep + workload + conflict + body + time) ÷ 20
```

The answer runs from 0 to 1, and **higher means heavier**. Under 0.30 is a light load, 0.30 up to 0.60 a medium load, and 0.60 or more a high load. (The worksheet splits each band in two for its words: very light under 0.15, light, medium on the lighter side under 0.45, medium on the heavier side, high under 0.80, and very high from 0.80.) Your **battery** is the other side of the same thing, the energy you have left: a high load means a low battery. The battery is a picture in words, not a second score.

> WORKED EXAMPLE Rosa, from Part Two, Chapter III, page , scores sleep 3, workload 4, conflict 1, body 2 and time 3.
>
> `3 + 4 + 1 + 2 + 3 = 13; 13 ÷ 20 = 0.65`, which is a high load.

Two or more of you: each person scores only themselves, and the shared figure is the plain average of everyone's own scores. If any one person is at 0.60 or more, treat that as the headline, whatever the average says.

Coming back after a pause (the Calm-Down Kit): if you like numbers, take the score again after a calming round. Under 0.50, go back at the time you named. From 0.50

to 0.59, take another round. At 0.60 or more after two rounds, put it off to a named time. The kit's line sits at 0.50 on purpose: you don't need a light load to come back, just less than half.

Today's Weather: the room in your day

Today's Weather shows words, not numbers: a sky (clear, gusty or fogged in) and how much room you have today. Behind the words sits a rough tally from 0 to 100, where **higher means a heavier day**. You only see it if you tick "Show the numbers behind this".

WHAT YOU PICKED	ADDS
The sky: clear, gusty, fogged in	0, 26, 34
The pressure: light, building, heavy (skipped: 6)	0, 10, 20
Last night's sleep: properly rested, about enough, short night, barely slept (skipped: 6)	0, 2, 10, 18
People load: barely any, a normal amount, a lot, nonstop (skipped: 4)	0, 3, 9, 14
Ground conditions (hungry, thirsty, in pain and so on)	4 each, up to 14
What's blowing in (work, money, health and so on)	3 each, up to 10

Under 45 reads as lots of room today, 45 to 64 as some room, and 65 or more as very little room.

> WORKED EXAMPLE Joel, from Part One, Now, page , picks gusty, building pressure, a short night, a lot of people time, one ground condition (hungry) and one thing blowing in (work).
>
> `26 + 10 + 10 + 9 + 4 + 3 = 62`: some room today, with less than usual, so the forecast says to go gently and settle first.

Workload balance: how evenly the hours are shared

Two people. Work out each person's share of the logged hours as a percentage.

```
balance = 1 − (the difference between the two percentages ÷ 100)
```

50/50 scores 1.00; one person doing everything scores 0.00. It doesn't matter which of you does more. Balance ignores the total, which is one reason the load sits beside it.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosemary logs 14 hours and Ken 10 (Part Two, Chapter II, page **18**). Out of 24 hours, that is 58.3% and 41.7%.

`1 − (58.3 − 41.7) ÷ 100 = 1 − 0.167 = 0.83`

Three or more people, or an agreed split. The same idea, said more generally: how much of the week would have to change hands to reach the target, compared with the most that ever could.

```
each share = that person's hours ÷ everyone's hours
target     = an even share (1 ÷ number of people), or the split you
agreed
moved      = ½ × the sum of every |share − target|
most       = 1 − the smallest target share
balance    = 1 − moved ÷ most
```

WORKED EXAMPLE Three partners log 15, 9 and 6 hours (Chapter II, page **18**): shares 0.50, 0.30 and 0.20, against a third each.

`moved = ½ × (0.167 + 0.033 + 0.133) = 0.167; most = 1 − 0.333 = 0.667; balance = 1 − 0.167 ÷ 0.667 = 0.75`. In hours, 0.167 × 30 = 5 hours a week would change hands for an even split.

With an agreed split, use it as the target: co-parents who agreed 60/40 and log 12 and 8 hours score 1.00.

Ownership: does every job have a name?

```
ownership = jobs with a named owner ÷ all the jobs on the list
```

The calculator counts a job as owned when it has one named owner. A backstop, the person who notices if it slipped, is a good habit and has its own column, but the score only needs the owner. The starter jobs on the worksheet don't count until you give them an owner or change them. Never raise the score by deleting the jobs nobody owns: they are exactly what the score is there to show.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosemary and Ken list 12 regular jobs, and 9 have an owner: `9 ÷ 12 = 0.75`.

Who carries more of the list. A score of 1.00 can still mean one person owns everything, so One owner per job also shows each person's share of the list, with each job weighted by how often it comes round and how big it is:

```
weight of a job = how often × size
how often: daily 5, weekly 1, ongoing 1, monthly 0.25, as needed 0.1
size:      small 0.5, medium 1 (the default), big 2
           (or, where you gave the hours each time: hours ÷ 0.5)
share      = the weights of that person's jobs ÷ the weights of all
the jobs
```

A job you decide together counts the same for each of you; on a list for two homes it shows as "Together" instead.

WORKED EXAMPLE One person owns the cooking (daily, medium: 5) and the bills (monthly, medium: 0.25). The other owns the laundry (weekly, big: 2) and the car (as needed, medium: 0.1). Each owns two jobs, but `5.25 ÷ 7.35 = 71%` of the list's weight sits with the first person, and 29% with the second.

Who's carrying more right now. Who did what flags the busiest person when their share of the logged minutes (or of the work done without being asked) is at least half, and at least 20 points over an even share: 70% or more for two people, 53% or more for three. In the Preface, page 's example, one partner did 105 of the 115 minutes that were noticed and handled without anyone asking: 91%, so the sheet says so.

The setup score: can the way you share the work last?

```
setup score = balance × 0.40
            + ownership × 0.35
            + (1 − the average load) × 0.25
```

The weights add up to 1, so the score runs from 0 to 1, and here **higher means the setup is working better**, the opposite of the load. The load is the only part that counts against the score, which is why it enters as 1 − load. 0.70 or more reads as working well (the Lemonade Stand says "holding"); 0.40 up to 0.70 as needs a look

("drifting"); below 0.40 as needs a rethink, together. It is a snapshot of the setup, never a probability and never a verdict on anyone.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosemary and Ken (Chapter II, page **18**): balance 0.83, ownership 0.75, and their own load scores are 0.45 and 0.30, an average of 0.375.

`0.83 × 0.40 + 0.75 × 0.35 + (1 − 0.375) × 0.25 = 0.333 + 0.263 + 0.156 = 0.75`: working well.

The shortfall is what each part could have earned minus what it did earn: balance 0.40 − 0.333 = 0.067; ownership 0.35 − 0.263 = 0.088; load 0.25 − 0.156 = 0.094. The biggest shortfall is the load, which usually eases outside the chore list (more sleep, a lighter week elsewhere). The calculator's "what would help most" is the single change with the biggest gain: handing about 2 hours a week from Rosemary to Ken would take balance from 0.83 to 1.00, worth 0.067. Naming one more job's owner would be worth 0.029, and a load lower by 0.10 on average 0.025.

The overall score adds a fourth part, retuning: of the moments that landed badly this week, how many you retuned before answering.

```
overall = balance × 0.35 + ownership × 0.30 + (1 − load) × 0.20 +
retuning × 0.15
(no rough moments this week: leave retuning out, and divide the first
three parts by 0.85)
```

In Chapter II's first worked example (balance 0.60, ownership 0.80, an average load of 0.40, and 3 of 5 rough moments retuned): `0.21 + 0.24 + 0.12 + 0.09 = 0.66`.

The 30-day look-back: what shifted this month?

The look-back splits the last 30 days into four weeks (the first takes the first ten days). For each part you filled in (balance, ownership, the load, and last-minute rescues), it compares the start of the month with the end:

```
start = the average of weeks 1 and 2
end   = the average of weeks 3 and 4
it shifted if end − start is 0.10 or more (balance, ownership, load),
           or 1 a week or more (rescues); anything smaller didn't
shift
```

One next step: a part that moved the wrong way comes first (the biggest move for its size). Otherwise, the first of these that is still true at the end: ownership under 0.70, balance under 0.70, 2 or more rescues a week, or anyone's load at 0.60 or more. If none is, keep the same rhythm and look again in 30 days.

Hours to change hands over the month: for each person, the hours they did minus their share of everyone's hours, added up week by week. Half the sum of those gaps (ignoring the minus signs) is how many hours would change hands to make the month even.

WORKED EXAMPLE Suppose Rosemary and Ken keep going for a month (made up, like them). Their four weeks: hours 14 and 10, 15 and 9, 13 and 11, 12 and 12; jobs with an owner 9, 9, 11 and 11 of 12; Rosemary's load 0.45, 0.50, 0.40, 0.35 and Ken's 0.30 every week; rescues 3, 2, 1, 1.

PART	START (WEEKS 1–2)	END (WEEKS 3–4)	CHANGE	READS AS
Balance	(0.83 + 0.75) ÷ 2 = 0.79	(0.92 + 1.00) ÷ 2 = 0.96	+0.17	Better
Ownership	0.75	0.92	+0.17	Better
Average load	0.39	0.34	−0.05	About the same
Rosemary's own load	0.48	0.38	−0.10	Lighter
Rescues a week	2.5	1	−1.5	Fewer

Three of the four parts shifted, all for the better, and nothing is left on the watch list, so the next step is to keep the rhythm. The setup score went from 0.73 to 0.87. Over the month Rosemary did 54 hours and Ken 42, so 6 hours would have changed hands for an even month.

On your own: is your week sustainable?

The Lemonade Stand's "just me" view adds up the hours your week is spoken for (jobs, the thinking work, care and so on) and compares them with a waking week of about 112 hours (16 waking hours, 7 days).

```
share = the hours spoken for ÷ 112
```

Under 50% reads as sustainable, 50% up to 70% as full but workable, and 70% or more as stretched. A made-up example: 50 hours spoken for is 45%, which leaves real room; 80 hours is 71%, a lot to keep up week after week.

All of these are this book's own ways of putting things into numbers. They have not been tested in research studies, and they shouldn't be quoted as findings. The free calculators on the website do the arithmetic for you, and each one has a "How is this worked out?" note.

Blank worksheets

Photocopy or print these pages, as many times as you like, and fill them in by hand. Each one is a blank copy of a worksheet in the book. The free fillable versions on the website do the sums for you, and keep what you type on your own device.

Who did what

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01.html

Write down what actually happened this week, before anyone starts remembering it as a story. Write down only what you did or saw yourself; never fill in someone else's side for them.

Person A _____ Person B _____

Week beginning _____

Part A: Who did what, this week

One row for each task noticed or done, including the invisible ones: remembering, planning, booking, forms. Time spent only thinking, noticing or planning counts too: log it as "Thinking and planning".

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?

This week's totals

Person A: minutes (and %), of which noticed and handled without being asked _____

Person B: minutes (and %), of which noticed and handled without being asked _____

Workload balance score: 1 − (A% − B%, ignoring any minus sign) ÷ 100 = _____

Part B (optional), Kind ways to say no: say why the request is fair, say honestly what you have left, and offer something instead.

Describes how the logged work was split this week, not anyone in it. How the score works: "How the numbers work", at the back.

How much are you carrying?

Fillable version: spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02.html

Fill this in on your own, about yourself only. Never fill it in for someone else.

Your name _____ Date _____

The checklist

Score each row based on how the last 24–48 hours have actually gone. Circle one: 0 = Not at all, 4 = Very true. Living with a long-term illness? Your physical row may always be high. That is load, not a mood.

	Not at all				Very true
Sleep debt (less rested than usual)	0	1	2	3	4
Workload elsewhere (job, school, caregiving)	0	1	2	3	4
Recent unresolved conflict (any source)	0	1	2	3	4
Physical state (hungry, sick, in pain)	0	1	2	3	4
Time pressure today specifically	0	1	2	3	4

Your load score

Points (add the five circled numbers): _____ out of 20

Load score: points ÷ 20 = _____ out of 1.00

Higher means a heavier load (and a lower battery). Under 0.30: light. 0.30 to 0.59: medium. 0.60 or more: high. Put off anything that doesn't need deciding in the next hour.

Optional

☐ Some of what I'm carrying is caring for someone

Anything you want to name before talking

A high score is a way to press pause, not a way out. It means "let's come back to this tomorrow," not "this doesn't need to happen."

One owner per job

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03.html

Every regular job gets one owner: the person who does it and sees it through. If you like, add a helper or backup who pitches in, notices if it slips, or covers it on a bad week. List the invisible jobs too: forms, gifts, renewals, planning, appointments.

Date of this list

The split you agreed (optional)

Who owns each job

Job	How often	Owner	Helper or backup (optional)	Size (optional)	Notes

How often: Daily, Weekly, Monthly, As needed, Ongoing. Size: Small, Medium, Big.

Does every job have an owner?

Jobs with an owner: _____ of _____ = _____ out of 1.00

Changes to the list (optional)

Date	What changed	Who

Where we've landed

Agreeing means everyone has read this version and knows who owns what. It doesn't mean every job feels perfectly fair, only that ownership is clear.

☐ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)

Look at this again on (optional)

What keeps coming back?

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04.html

A monthly look-back, done together, across four weeks of Who did what and One owner per job. It looks for the tasks that keep slipping. The goal is to find where the setup needs a fix, not to tally what anyone owes.

Month

Part A: Gather the month's notes

List every task that was noticed but not done, or done only after being raised more than once. Mark an ✗ for each week it came up.

Task	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4	Times flagged

Part B: Sort each gap

Sort every task flagged twice or more. A **structural gap** has no clear owner (fix One owner per job now). A **capacity issue** has an owner who can't keep up (set a time for an honest conversation). A **one-off** has a temporary cause (note it and move on).

Task	Named owner on the job list? (Yes / No)	Classification	Action

Part C: Wrap up the audit

Structural gaps found

Capacity issues found

One-offs

Part D (optional): Thanked, or only noticed when it's missed?

Job	Gets thanked (Often / Sometimes / Rarely / Never)	Only noticed when missed? (Yes / No)	One way to notice it

Not a bill for the past, and not a performance review. A task with no owner is a gap in the setup, not a verdict on the person who kept covering it.

Say it so it lands

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09.html

A self-check each of you uses on your own side of a conversation. Use it on one thing that actually stung.

Your name _____ Date _____

Before you speak or send: fact, feeling, ask

Raw reaction (optional, and just for you)

What's the fact underneath this? (One sentence, no adjectives.) For example: "The bins went out late on Tuesday."

What's the feeling underneath this? (Frustrated, tired, unseen, rushed…) A feeling about you, not a verdict about them.

What's the actual ask? (What do you want to happen next, specifically?) Something the other person can say yes to.

Before you react: four quick checks

Check	Circle one
Is this about a specific, nameable task or event?	Yes · No
Would I read this the same way if I weren't already carrying a lot?	Yes · No · Not sure
Is there a neutral interpretation that also fits what was said?	Yes · No
Am I responding to their words, or to a pattern from a past conversation?	Their words · A past pattern

A "No" or "Not sure" on the second check, a "Yes" on the third or "A past pattern" on the fourth are good reasons to pause first. A kind "not right now" and a time to come back keeps it honest.

The Calm-Down Kit

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11.html

A short plan, made ahead of time, for calming your body down enough to have the conversation, or to put it off honestly. Fill in Part A on an ordinary day, not a hard one. Your kit is yours; only the pause plan is made to share.

Whose kit is this? (your name) _____ Date _____

Part A: What tends to start it

What tends to start it	How it shows up in my body first

Part A: My two defaults

Pick two calming steps now: asymmetric breathing (breathe in for 4, out for 6) · naming the room (5 things you see, 4 you hear, 3 you can touch) · weight and pressure (feet pressed flat into the floor, or something warm held in both hands) · gating (cutting noise and light: lower the lights, step out) · walking it out · a low, steady sound.

First default _____ Second, if the first isn't available _____

Part A: My pause line

Say how you are, how long you need, and when you'll be back: "I'm at capacity. I need ten minutes. I'll be back at quarter past."

_____

Our pause plan (agree it together, and share it)

Our pause word or signal _____ The shortest break we take _____

How we set the time to come back _____ The first sentence when we come back _____

Part B, in the moment: say your pause word or line, then do your first calming step.

Part C: Coming back

Still hot? Another round. Twice? Name a new time. Settled enough to listen? Go back at the time you named. (For number fans: your load score, 0 to 1. Under 0.50 go back; 0.50 to 0.59 another round; 0.60 or above after two rounds, put it off.)

Time	What I did	How I feel now (Still hot / Settled enough)	Load before (0–1)	Load after (0–1)

Next small action _____ If you put the conversation off: when you'll pick it back up _____

Where I've landed

☐ I'm going with this

Look at this again on (optional) _____

Nothing in this kit works by cold, pain or shock, and none of it is treatment.

The 90-second daily check-in

Fillable version: spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-13.html

Each person answers each prompt in one sentence, about their own day, and fills in only their own rows. No debating, no solving, no arguing back. Anything that needs a real discussion waits for the weekly catch-up.

Week beginning

Each day

Day	Person	Load (Low / Medium / High)	One thing I appreciated today	One small thing that didn't feel great	One thing that would help tomorrow
Mon					
Mon					
Tue					
Tue					
Wed					
Wed					
Thu					
Thu					
Fri					
Fri					
Sat					
Sat					
Sun					
Sun					

The weekly catch-up (optional)

Skim the week for anything that came up more than twice, and move it to the right worksheet.

Sore spot that keeps coming up	Times this week	Move to (One owner per job / Say it so it lands / Keep watching)

Where we've landed

☐ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)

Look at this again on (optional)

Same moment, different speeds

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-12.html

For a few moments that come round often, each person marks how fast they want to move, how much they want to talk, and how urgent it feels. Each person fills in only their own rows, ideally before looking at the other's. There are no right answers.

Date

Part A: Each person's speed

Speed: right away · within the hour · later the same day · after a night's sleep. Talk: quiet time first · a few words, then act · talk it all through. Urgency: low · medium · high.

Moment	Person	Speed	Talk	Urgency	What helps me (optional)
A plan changes at the last minute					
A bill, letter or form needs dealing with					
Something breaks or goes wrong at home					
One of us is upset about something					
Deciding what to do with free time					

Part B: Where your speeds differ

For each moment, count how many steps apart your answers are on each list. Start with the biggest gap: a difference in pace, not in how much anyone cares.

Part C: One small agreement

Moment	What we'll try	Try it until

Where we've landed

Agreeing means you have both seen the gaps and will try the agreement. It doesn't mean either of you has to change speed for good.

☐ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)

Look at this again on (optional)

Not a compatibility test and not a diagnosis. Run it again every few months, or after a big change.

Is it us, or is it everything else?

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-14.html

A one-week log that keeps two things apart: pressure from outside (money, work, health, sleep, family) and friction that really starts between you. A line or two each evening, each person about their own day. Write what happened, not who was wrong.

Week beginning

Part A: Each evening

Day	Person	Outside pressure today (None / A little / A lot)	Where it came from	A tense moment between us (if any)	Looking back, it was mostly (Outside pressure / Between us / Some of both / Not sure yet)
Mon					
Mon					
Tue					
Tue					
Wed					
Wed					
Thu					
Thu					
Fri					
Fri					
Sat					
Sat					
Sun					
Sun					

Part B: The week at a glance

Tense moments on heavy days: _____ of _____

Part C: What got blamed on the wrong thing?

The moment	What it seemed to be about	What was really going on	What would help next time

Part D: One plan for the pressure

The pressure we're facing right now

How we'll flag a heavy day

What we'll go easy on until it passes

One bit of outside help we could ask for (optional)

Outside pressure explains a hard day. It doesn't excuse unkindness, and it doesn't make what anyone felt less real.

Keep your little rituals alive

Fillable version: spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-15.html

Every three months or so, a short look at the small shared habits that keep you close: the morning coffee, the Sunday walk, the birthday breakfast. Nobody is to blame for one that lapsed.

Date

Part A: Our rituals, big and small

How it's doing: Alive (still happening, still means something) · Fading (on autopilot or less often) · Stopped · New idea. How often: Daily, Weekly, Monthly, Yearly, Now and then.

Ritual or habit	How often	How it's doing	What it gives us, or what got in the way

Part C: One to restart, or start

The ritual

The smallest version that still counts

The first time: when, and who will suggest it

What would make it easy to skip, and how we'll protect it (optional)

Part D (optional): One to let go, with thanks

The ritual

What it gave us

Where we've landed

☐ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)

Look at this again on (optional)

A ritual is something you would both miss, not a test of love. Look at this sheet again in about three months.

Words used in this book

The book's own words, each in one plain sentence. More at spreadloveandacceptance.com/glossary.

Alexithymia

Finding it hard to notice, name or describe your own feelings. It is a trait on a scale, not an illness, and it is more common in some autistic people. Naming body signals first can help.

Backstop

The second name on a job: someone who notices if it slipped and checks in kindly. Not a supervisor. A job counts as owned once it has an owner; the backstop is a good habit on top.

Battery

Your battery is how much energy you have left today. Full means you have room to spare; low means you're running on empty. "How much are you carrying?" measures the other side of it, your load: a higher load score means a heavier load, and a lower battery.

For example: After a poor night and a long workday, your load score is high and your battery is low, so a small request feels big.

A bid

A bid is any small reach for attention or connection, like "look at this," a sigh or a joke.

For example: They show you a photo of a dog. Looking and smiling back is turning towards it.

Calm-Down Kit

The Calm-Down Kit is your own short list of what settles your body, chosen ahead of time so you don't have to think when you're wound up.

For example: A glass of cold water, a walk to the corner, and three long breaths out.

Carrier wave

The carrier wave is the feeling that travels underneath the words: the tone that arrives before the meaning does.

For example: "Fine." can carry calm, hurt or tiredness. The carrier wave tells you which.

Check-in

A check-in is a short, planned talk that keeps small things small. The daily one takes about ninety seconds, with no debating.

For example: "Load today: heavy. Thank you for the dishes. One small thing: the car. My ask: could you fill it up?"

Complacency

Complacency is what happens when something has worked for a long time and you stop checking on it. It isn't laziness or a lack of love. It's a setup nobody has looked at lately.

For example: "How was your day?" "Fine." Months go by and nobody has asked a real question.

Double empathy

The idea, from the autistic researcher Damian Milton, that misunderstandings between autistic and non-autistic people run both ways: each finds the other hard to read, so neither side is simply "missing" something.

Drift

Drift is how two people slowly fall out of step when nobody checks in, even when nothing is wrong.

For example: Three busy weeks, no real talk, and small things start to feel big.

Flooded

Flooded means being so wound up that listening stops working for a while. The kind thing is a short pause with a time to come back.

For example: "I need twenty minutes. Can we talk again at eight?"

Frequency

Your frequency is your natural pace: how fast you decide, talk, reply and recover.

For example: One person answers a text in a minute; the other answers at the end of the day. Neither is wrong.

Gatekeeping

Holding on to how a home or child-care job must be done, so the other person steps back. Researchers first described it in mothers ("maternal gatekeeping"), but anyone can do it.

Groupthink

When a close group wants agreement so much that doubts go unsaid and a poor decision goes ahead. Irving Janis named it in 1972.

If-then plan

A small plan written as "If this happens, then I will do that", which makes a new habit easier to start (Peter Gollwitzer).

A kind no

A kind no says what you can and can't do right now, without blaming anyone.

For example: "I can't take that on this week. I could help on Saturday."

Kinship care

When a grandparent, aunt, older sibling or family friend raises a child whose parents can't.

The ladder

Three everyday states: calm and connected, revved up, running on empty. Today's Weather calls them clear, gusty and fogged in. A best guess about your state, not a measurement.

Ledger

A notebook where you write down what happened, so you can look at it calmly later. The book's title means just that: see what is really going on, without blame, then change one small thing.

The load

The load is all the work of a shared life, including the thinking, planning and remembering that nobody sees.

For example: Buying the gift is one job. Remembering the birthday, picking the gift and wrapping it are three more.

Masking

Masking is hiding the way you're wired to fit in, which can be very tiring over time.

For example: Forcing eye contact and rehearsing small talk all day, then needing the evening to recover.

Mental load

The noticing, planning and remembering behind running a shared life: knowing the shoes are too small, booking the appointment, keeping the list. It is real work, even though nobody sees it.

Monotropism

A theory of autistic attention: attention gathers deeply on a few things at a time, rather than spreading thinly across many. Switching away can take real effort.

Owner (one owner per job)

The owner of a job is the one person who makes sure it gets done from start to finish, so nobody has to keep asking.

For example: Sam owns the recycling: noticing it's full, taking it out and buying the bags.

Parallel parenting

Co-parenting with as little direct contact as possible: each home runs its own way, and messages stay short, polite and about the children.

Pressure

Pressure, in Today's Weather, is how much you were already carrying today: light, building or heavy. Behind the forecast sits a rough tally from 0 to 100; under 45 leaves room in the day, 65 or more means go gently. It is a reading of what you told it, not a score or a grade.

For example: A pressure of 40 leaves room in the day; 75 means go gently and leave big things for later.

Prolonged grief

Grief that stays intense and gets in the way of daily life for a long time after a death (usually a year or more for adults). It is treatable; a GP or doctor is a good first step.

Psychological safety

A shared sense in a group or team that you can speak up, ask a question or admit a mistake without being punished or embarrassed (Amy Edmondson).

Repair

A repair is anything that stops a tense moment from getting worse, like a joke, a softer tone or "Can we start over?"

For example: "I said that badly. What I meant was…"

Retune

To retune is to notice you've fallen out of step with someone and adjust together: slower, softer, or at a better time.

For example: "Can we start that again? I came in too fast."

The rulebook from home

The rulebook from home is the unwritten set of rules you grew up with, about love, upset, chores and rest, that you may still expect others to follow.

For example: "Whoever notices the mess cleans it" was the rule at home, so a messy kitchen feels like "It's always me."

Rumination

Going over the same worry or regret again and again without getting closer to an answer.

Second arrow

The extra pain we add on top of a hard moment, such as being angry at ourselves for being sad. The first arrow is the event; the second is what we tell ourselves about it (a Buddhist image).

Setup score

The one number from Is the setup working for everyone?: balance, ownership and stress added up with weights (0.40, 0.35 and 0.25), from 0 to 1. 0.70 and up is working well, 0.40 to 0.69 needs a look, under 0.40 needs a rethink, together. It judges the setup, never a person.

Static

Static is the crackle between two people when the words are fine but the tone, pace or timing doesn't match.

For example: You ask "When will you do it?" calmly. They hear pressure. Nobody meant harm, but it crackles.

Stress tank

How much stress you are already carrying, from How much are you carrying?: a load score from 0 (empty) to 1 (full). Under 0.30 is low, 0.30 to 0.59 moderate, 0.60 and up high. A fuller tank means less room to take more on. (Your battery is the other side of it: energy left.)

Talk window

The talk window says whether now is a good time for a big conversation: open, wait a little, or closed for today.

For example: Your window says "wait," so you ask to talk after dinner instead of right now.

Today's Weather

Today's Weather is a one-minute check on your own conditions today, like sleep, stress and energy: Clear means calm and connected, Gusty means revved up, and Fogged in means running on empty.

For example: Short night, busy day: the forecast says to keep big talks for tomorrow.

Unbilled debt

Unbilled debt is the work of a shared life that got done but was never noticed or thanked.

For example: You remembered the dentist appointment, and nobody knew there was anything to remember.

Wave Code

Four letters from the Wavelength quiz, one for each of four preferences about how you take in and send words. Each letter shows where you lean on a dial today: a shorthand for preferences, not a personality type.

Window of tolerance

The range in which you can feel strong feelings and still think and talk. Above it you are flooded or revved up; below it you shut down. A phrase from the psychiatrist Dan Siegel.

Wired differently

Being wired differently means your brain works in a less common way, such as being autistic, ADHD, dyslexic or highly sensitive, which changes how words land.

For example: A hint like "the bins are full" may be heard as a plain fact, not a request.

Wiring

Your wiring is the way your brain and senses take in words, sound, change and people. It stays the same from day to day.

For example: Some people need a plan in writing. Others think best out loud.

Workpaper

A workpaper is a short worksheet. Each person fills in their own, then you read them together.

For example: "Who did what" is a week's log of who did what.

Your lens

Your lens is the set of understandings about yourself, other people and what they owe you that you picked up growing up and still use without noticing.

For example: "Rest is earned" can feel like plain fact, until you notice it was your family's rule.

List of figures

Figure 1 How the three parts fit together · *Front of the book* 14

Figure 2 Five ideas the whole book rests on · *Front of the book* 15

Figure 13 Is the split working? · *Is the split working?* 20

List of filled-in examples

Example 8 — The Lemonade Stand: quick look · *Wren, Josh and Mei, housemates (Wren's view) · Is the split working?* 21

Example 9 — Is the setup working for everyone? · *Rosemary and Ken, retired, married 41 years · Is the split working?* 24

Example 10 — Our room agreement · *Kayla and Bea, first-year roommates · Is the split working?* 31

Example 11 — Who did what, with small children · *Hollie and Gareth, parents of a toddler and a baby; Gareth works shifts · Is the split working?* 34

Research notes

The 445 studies and books the chapters mention, chapter by chapter, each with what it found in plain words and where to read it. Each entry was looked up and checked: most against the paper itself or its abstract, some (mostly older books) against a publisher's or library's record. Unchecked works are left out. The full list, with notes on how strong each finding is, is at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Reading research: a few words in plain English

The chapters often say how sure the research is: "a small study", "linked with", "didn't replicate". Here is what those words mean, so every note in the book is something you can weigh for yourself.

Correlational ("linked with")
Two things tend to go together: people who sleep less tend to argue more. It doesn't show which causes which, or whether a third thing, like a new baby, causes both.

Experiment
Researchers change one thing on purpose, ideally deciding by chance who gets it, and compare. Better at showing cause, though often in a lab, for a short time, with a small group.

Meta-analysis
A study of studies: it pools many studies of the same question. Usually more trustworthy than any one study, but only as good as the studies in it.

Replication
Doing a study again to see if the result holds. When a large team re-ran 100 published psychology studies in 2015, only about a third gave a clear result again, and the effects were on average about half as big. So one study is a start, not the end.

Effect size
How big a difference is, not just whether there is one. A result can be real ("significant") and still tiny. The book says "small" or "modest" when that is the case.

Who was studied
Much of psychology studies students in Western, educated, well-off countries. A finding may not fit every age, culture or kind of family, and many studies of couples looked only at a mother and a father.

Self-report
People answered questions about themselves. That is often the only way to ask about feelings, but memory and wanting to look good both creep in.

How the book labels things: a *Research note* describes published findings in plain words and says where the evidence is thin. *This site's idea* marks the book's own ways of putting things into practice, such as the worksheets and the setup score, which have not been tested in studies. The full list at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research also says how strong each finding is: strong, moderate or early.

PART TWO · CHAPTER II

Is the split working?

Cohen, S., Kamarck, T., & Mermelstein, R. (1983). A *global measure of perceived stress.* Journal of Health and Social Behavior, 24(4), 385–396. Introduced the Perceived Stress Scale, a short questionnaire about how unpredictable, uncontrollable and overloaded your life has felt lately; scores went with symptoms of depression and illness.
doi.org/10.2307/2136404

Cowan, C. P., & Cowan, P. A. (1992). *When Partners Become Parents: The Big Life Change for Couples.* BasicBooks (New York); reissued 1999 (Erlbaum) and 2011. Based on the Becoming a Family Project, a long-term study of expectant couples, describes how strain and conflict between partners commonly rise across the transition to parenthood, and tests couples groups as prevention.
openlibrary.org/works/OL92708W

Daminger, A. (2019). *The cognitive dimension of household labor.* American Sociological Review, 84(4), 609–633. Interviews with 35 couples (70 interviews) identified four parts of household "cognitive labour": anticipating needs, identifying options, deciding, and monitoring. Women did more of it overall, especially anticipating and monitoring; deciding was shared more equally. The work was often unseen by both partners.
doi.org/10.1177/0003122419859007

Darley, J. M., & Latané, B. (1968). *Bystander intervention in emergencies: Diffusion of responsibility.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 8(4), 377–383. Participants who believed others could also hear a person having a seizure were slower and less likely to help; the presence of others reduced each person's sense of responsibility.
doi.org/10.1037/h0025589

di Leonardo, M. (1987). *The female world of cards and holidays: Women, families, and the work of kinship.* Signs: Journal of Women in Culture and Society, 12(3), 440–453. Named "kin work": the cards, calls, visits, gifts and gatherings that keep extended families connected. In the families she studied, it was done mostly by women and often treated as effortless.
doi.org/10.1086/494338

Doss, B. D., Rhoades, G. K., Stanley, S. M., & Markman, H. J. (2009). *The effect of the transition to parenthood on relationship quality: An 8-year prospective study.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 96(3), 601–619. Following 218 couples over the first eight years of marriage, those who had a first child showed sudden declines in relationship quality after the birth, on average, compared with couples who did not.
doi.org/10.1037/a0013969

Feinberg, M. E., & Kan, M. L. (2008). *Establishing Family Foundations: Intervention effects on coparenting, parent/infant well-being, and parent-child relations.* Journal of Family Psychology, 22(2), 253–263. A randomised trial with 169 expectant first-time couples found that the Family Foundations classes, delivered before and after birth, improved coparenting and some aspects of parent and infant wellbeing at follow-up.
doi.org/10.1037/0893-3200.22.2.253

Goodhart, C. A. E. (1975). *Problems of monetary management: The U.K. experience.* Paper presented at the Conference in Monetary Economics, Sydney, July 1975; published in Papers in Monetary Economics, Vol. I (Reserve Bank of Australia, 1976); reprinted in Goodhart, Monetary Theory and Practice (Macmillan, 1984). The original source of "Goodhart's law": a statistical regularity tends to break down once authorities put pressure on it for control purposes.
rba.gov.au/publications/rdp/1990/9013/conference-volumes.html

Hochschild, A. R., with Machung, A. (1989). *The Second Shift: Working Parents and the Revolution at Home.* Viking Penguin (updated edition 2012, Penguin Books). Interviews and home observations of dual-earner couples with young children found that working mothers did much more of the housework and childcare, adding up to a large extra load over a year; many couples told themselves stories that the split was fair.
penguinrandomhouse.com

Kurdek, L. A. (2007). *The allocation of household labor by partners in gay and lesbian couples.* Journal of Family Issues, 28(1), 132–148. Among 43 gay and 36 lesbian couples where both partners worked full-time, household tasks were divided more evenly than is typical in heterosexual couples, often by negotiation and specialisation rather than gender.
doi.org/10.1177/0192513X06292019

Ross, M., & Sicoly, F. (1979). *Egocentric biases in availability and attribution.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 37(3), 322–336. In five experiments (married couples, groups, basketball teams), people recalled more of their own contributions to joint work and took more responsibility than others gave them; spouses' estimates of their own shares typically summed to more than 100 percent.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.37.3.322

Strathern, M. (1997). *'Improving ratings': Audit in the British University system.* European Review, 5(3), 305–321. Anthropological commentary on the "audit explosion" in British universities; widely credited as the source of the popular phrasing of Goodhart's law (when a measure becomes a target, it stops being a good measure).
cambridge.org

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (annual, since 2003). *American Time Use Survey* (ATUS). Federal survey (conducted by the U.S. Census Bureau). The federal survey of how, where and with whom Americans spend their time, including unpaid housework and childcare; it has run every year since 2003.
bls.gov/tus

Yavorsky, J. E., Kamp Dush, C. M., & Schoppe-Sullivan, S. J. (2015). *The production of inequality: The gender division of labor across the transition to parenthood.* Journal of Marriage and Family, 77(3), 662–679. Time-diary data from dual-earner couples showed a gender gap in total work opening up after a first baby: mothers took on most of the added childcare without cutting their paid hours; survey reports overstated how equal things were.
doi.org/10.1111/jomf.12189

Index

Key ideas and the pages where the book talks about them. Chapter names are in the contents.

adult children 36
ageing, later life 24
appreciation, thanks 53
arguments 53
babies, new parents 18, 29, 32–34
backstop 22–23, 27, 29, 32, 41
balance (of the work) 18, 20–21, 25, 27, 35, 37, 40–44, 47
battery 29, 39, 48
blame 28, 55–56
breakups 28
Calm-Down Kit 39, 52
care, caring 48
carers, caregiving 30, 48
change 25–26, 28, 32, 37–38, 41, 43–44, 49, 54
check-in 25, 53
children 18, 28, 32–36
chores 18–19, 22, 31, 42–43, 51
co-parenting 36, 41–42
conflict 39, 48
coworkers 30
daily check-in (90 seconds) 53
debt, money worries 39, 48
disagreeing kindly 39
dorms, shared rooms 30–31
drift 24, 43
emotions, feelings 32, 51
empty nest 36
energy, matching 29
exams 19
fairness 18, 32, 47, 49
family 30, 35–36, 55
fathers, dads 23, 30, 36
foster care 30
friends 24, 28, 36
grandparents 23, 36
habits 23, 29, 38–39, 41, 56
helping 27, 38, 49
housemates 19, 21
How much are you carrying? 23, 25, 37, 39, 48
illness, long-term 30, 47–56
Is the setup working for everyone? 24–25
kinship care 30
ledger 18, 20, 22, 24, 26, 28, 30, 32, 34, 36, 38, 40, 42, 44, 46, 48, 50, 52, 54, 56
Lemonade Stand 21–22, 24, 42, 44
listening 52
love 28, 56
marriage 24
mental load 33
money 22, 29, 34, 36, 40, 42, 50, 54–55
monthly look-back 43, 50
more than two partners 21, 30, 41
One owner per job 19, 25–26, 37–38, 42, 49–50, 53
online life 30, 38
ownership, one owner per job 18–20, 22–30, 32–33, 35, 37–38, 41–44, 49–50, 53
parents 26, 30, 34, 36, 41
partners 21, 26, 29–30, 41–42
pause, taking a 26–27, 39, 48, 51–52
pressure 39–40, 48, 52, 55
resentment 29
rituals 56
safety 26, 29, 36
Say it so it lands 51, 53
self-worth 28, 43
separation 26
setup score 24, 27, 42, 44
shift work 30, 33, 35
siblings 23, 30
single, living alone 18, 26, 28, 44, 46, 48, 51
six-week program 38
sleep 30–31, 39–40, 43, 48, 54–55
stress 18–20, 23–24, 27, 29, 32, 37–38
stress tank 18, 20, 23–24, 27, 32, 36–38
teenagers 36
Today's Weather 40
unseen work 38
What keeps coming back? 50
Who did what 24, 34, 36–37, 42, 47, 50
work, the workplace 36
worry 28

A calm, practical book about the quiet work of sharing a life. It starts with you: where your lens came from, how you work today and who you are becoming. Then it looks at what happens between people who share a home, work or care. And it ends with how people work: feelings, stress, trust, change, loss, anger, love and the groups we belong to.

"See it fairly. Say it kindly."

- Two sizes of every chapter: short and full
- Everyday scenes, words you could use and one small thing to try
- Free tools and worksheets that stay on your device
- For every kind of relationship, and for people on their own



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